A promise is a product decision

Trace a claim through the first useful task.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE

PROMISE

A report in minutes

Expectation: I can try this now.

→

SETUP

Wait for approval

A requirement the claim did not explain.

→

RESULT

Open the first report

The result arrives after a different process.

Put the claim next to the actual task.

Keep the exact claim. Rewriting it during the review hides the disagreement.

Hypothetical product: a reporting tool promising a report in minutes.

CUSTOMER PROMISE

A report in minutes

The website creates an expectation before the customer knows how setup works.

FIRST USEFUL TASK

Create a report from a file

The customer needs a result they can inspect before choosing whether to continue.

Trace the expectation through the experience.

Read each step from the customer's side. Look for the point where the promise stops being believable.

01

PROMISE

A report in minutes

Expectation: I can try this now.

↓

02

SETUP

Wait for approval

A requirement the claim did not explain.

↓

03

RESULT

Open the first report

The result arrives after a different process.

Separate a copy gap from a capability gap.

The same complaint can require a different response. Diagnose the missing condition before choosing the work.

Observed moment	What is missing	Possible response
Approval is required, but never disclosed.	An expectation-setting message.	Explain the requirement before signup.
Approval is unnecessary for a sample report.	A path to try the product.	Offer a sample before approval.
All reports need a manual review.	A truthful promise.	Describe the actual process.

Compare the decisions, including their cost.

A narrower claim can be the right decision. A faster path can be the right decision. Each needs a reason.

CHANGE THE PROMISE

State the approval step

Less product work. The customer can decide whether the process suits them.

CHANGE THE EXPERIENCE

Let a sample run immediately

More product work. Check data limits and support cost before offering it.

Check the expectation before the click.

Show the revised claim and give the first task. Ask what the person expects to happen next.

Then watch the task. Record the moment their expectation differs from the product.

01 BEFORE

Expected result

What do they think they will get, and when?

↓

02 DURING

Observed attempt

Where do they hesitate or seek an explanation?

↓

03 AFTER

Account of the result

Can they explain the requirement in their own words?

Write a decision someone can act on.

Example decision: allow a sample report before approval. Keep approval for connecting a live account.

Review the claim again when the required setup changes.

Change and boundary

What will change? What will remain a requirement?

Evidence to inspect

Which customer expectation and task attempt should we observe?

Owner and review point

Who can make the change, and when will we inspect it?